INTER[ACTIVE]: ARTISTS AS AGENTS OF CHANGE

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ABSTRACT

This paper explores the role of electroacoustic composers in ecological crisis and introduces the *Sonic Ecologies Framework*, a multi-platform methodology to initiate cultural change through sound. The core of this methodology pivots on a site-specific creative project embedded in a multi-layered community cultural engagement process developed in response to a specific community. This evolving model is implemented by the artist, acting as an agent of change spiraling between contextualised theory and practice. This research presents results from a series of case studies implemented with this methodology and introduces the conceptual design of a major international project highlighting the future possibilities of this model.

INTRODUCTION

In 1937, in a talk titled *The Future of Music: Credo*, John Cage said, "I believe that the use of noise to make music will continue and increase until we reach a music produced through the aid of electrical instruments which will make available for musical purposes any and all sounds that can be heard" [2].

In 2012, the centennial of John Cage, his visionary genius is clearly evident with a musical world of infinite possibilities aided by technology. The dramatic advancement of technology has truly cultivated a paradigm shift in how artists interact in both physical and virtual worlds. These changes have evolved and expanded our tools of expression but most importantly they have opened the ability to communicate at a higher level in an interdisciplinary context.

In a recent addition of *Musicworks*, Joel Chadabe stated that the current artistic practices of electroacousitc composers are rooted in the idea that new technologies, unlike traditional musical instruments, can produce sounds used to communicate core messages, including information about the state of our environment. He claims that we are all participating in the emergence of a new type of music accessible to anyone, which can be used to communicate ideas that relate more closely to life than those communicated through traditional musical forms. He believes we need to think of ourselves as "leaders in a magnificent revolution rather than the defenders of an isolate and besieged avant-garde" [3].

In a world where the catastrophic effects of climate change are rapidly becoming a bitter reality, there must be a role for sound in generating a shift in consciousness. Bill McKidden recently said; "When art both of great worth, and in great quantities, begins to cluster around an issue, it means that civilization has identified it finally as a threat" [4]. He views artists as the antibodies of the cultural bloodstream and fundamental to social change. As this social movement of creative thinking expands internationally it is worth reflecting on Attali's seminal 1985 text where he refers to music as not just simply a reflection of culture but a "harbinger of change". He states, "For twenty-five centuries, western knowledge has tried to look upon the world. It has failed to understand that the world is not for the beholding. It is for hearing. It is not legible, but audible" [1].

World leaders now looking towards the validity and possibilities of creative methodologies as tools for change, this presents both a challenge and an unprecedented opportunity for composers to gain a critical understanding of the situation, and take action in devising new processes for a sustainable future. Electroacoustic music, with the use of natural sounds, has a profound ability to ignite an awareness and connection to the environment. But is the role of the artist purely to comment on the crisis? To create awareness? Or can provocation extend beyond expression to create a behavioral shift in deeply engrained unsustainable ways of thinking?

This research explores these questions and introduces a multi-platform methodology that could provide a framework to facilitate the paradigmatic shift required to initiate cultural change. The core of this methodology pivots of a site-specific electroacoustic music project embedded in a multi-layered community cultural engagement process developed in response to the specific community. The artist, acting as a change agent spiraling between contextualised theory and practice, implements this evolving model. The results are introduced through three case studies of projects recently produced by the author. This paper concludes with the conceptual design of a major international project developed with the *Sonic Ecologies Framework* highlighting the future possibilities of this model. These projects are ultimately acting as a catalyst and represent

an unparalleled opportunity for artists taking action as agents of change in environmental emergency.

RATIONAL

The author's practice-led doctoral research involved conceiving and delivering seven original electroacoustic projects for dissemination in multi-platform environments. The divergent projects were created in cultural immersion, spanning from ambitious sonic explorations in the center of the Amazon Jungle to sounding the rivers of the world through India, Korea, China, Australia and New Zealand. The delivery and dissemination of each project was underpinned by a rich methodology that pivots on the site-specific project embedded in community cultural engagement. The concept of cultural immersion challenges the traditional notion of an isolated composer and has the ability to be profoundly influential on the composer's personal validity of their practice. For the author, it is no longer about notes on a page with a dotted bar line that finishes the project, but an entire spectrum of compositional decisions in a constantly evolving process that appears to only expand rather than dissolve. This is undeniably as a result of working directly with the communities and experiencing creative inspiration in cultural immersion.

The ambitious doctoral research began as an exploration of the sustainability of electroacoustic music and evolved into a complex web of projects harnessing electroacoustic music as a change agent. The beginning was fueled by an isolated intention, yet through the process of cultural immersion the author discovered a tool that not only provides a gratified language of creative expression, but also a voice for the communities and environments collaborating on these projects. The discoveries and observations from each individual project showed a clear trajectory towards a definitive set of tools to initiate cultural change through environmental electroacoustic music. As a result, the *Sonic Ecologies Framework* was developed as a means to create an accessible methodology for composers' interested in implementing similar projects.

SONIC ECOLOGIES FRAMEWORK

The following provides a brief overview of the five essential elements of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework*. The core of this methodology pivots on a site-specific electroacoustic music project embedded in a multi-layered community cultural engagement process developed in response to a specific community. The site specificity requires that this methodology be intrinsically flexible in order to be adaptable within a diversity of environments and communities. It is in essence a practice-led creative research process, taking an ecological approach to contextualising a project within an environment. While there is an essential degree of freedom and adaptability, the process is grounded within the theoretical contexts generated by the artists who experiment and innovate within a continual spiraling between theory and practice.

Site-specific Subject Matter

In the context of this process, the site-specific nature of the electroacoustic music project is essential. It must be pertinent to the community and grounded within a comprehensive understanding of the proposed thematic content. The sound work of Douglas Quin in Antarctica and Francisco Lopez in the Central Amazon Jungle are obvious examples.

Multi-platform Dissemination

The *Sonic Ecologies Framework* encourages collaboration and multiple outcomes where possible. While one core creative outcome is most likely the central intention, the adaptability of the project for a range of environments is essential. The sonic outcomes should be disseminated in a range of environments for maximum exposure; this includes harnessing the power of virtual platforms to facilitate global accessibility. This is exemplified in the *EcoSonus* project commissioned *Floating Land 2009*, a multi-channel sound installation with regional site-specific performances, collaborative community compositions and a interactive website streaming field recordings and alternative compositions.

Community Engagement and Education Tools

There is undeniably a strong movement associated with environmental sound art emerging internationally. This is evident through the establishment of organisations such as *Ear to the Earth*, the environmental program of the *Electronic Music Foundation*. While this profusion of research continues to evolve, the reality is the western world is still a visually dominant society and requires education to ignite the auditory perception. If the community in question is to engage and comprehend the project, they must gain a deeper understanding of their sonic environment and play a role in the process. The community engagement and education tools will always evolve depending on the nature and accessibility of the proposed community but the standard suggestions include; community sound walks, participatory field recording sessions, capacity building workshops and providing access to the appropriate technology for the community to remain engaged in the process.

Interdisciplinary Partnerships and Collaborations

In order to truly attempt to create a paradigm shift with *Sonic Ecologies*, electroacoustic music must be augmented from its traditionally isolated academic circles and expand into regional communities collaborating with environmentalists, conservationists, scientists and policy makers to expand awareness. Creating a support network around the project will be essential in its future viability and sustainability.

Long-term Strategic Vision

The artist implementing the *Sonic Ecologies Framework* is initiating a process within a community. The creative outcomes serve as significant milestones but ultimately it is the process that will continue to resonate and evolve over time. As with any form of community engagement, *Sonic Ecologies* requires time in order to facilitate change. The capacity building community engagement is designed to empower the community to continue working long after the artist has departed. It is therefore essential the artist invests critical thought into the methods in which the community will continue to engage and appropriate technology is accessible to continue working. The most obvious strategy is to leave low costs digital recorders with a key stakeholder in the community and design a web platform to enable the community to continue creating and uploading content. It should also go without saying, plans to return to the community should be instigated by the artist, whether this be a concert of future creative outcomes, workshops or simply visiting the key collaborators to maintain relationships and energy in the process.

CASE STUDY: BLUE GOLD

The first case major study is *Blue Gold*, a performance installation investigating the delicate balance between wet and dry in our natural landscape by internationally acclaimed Australian sound artist Ros Bandt. The work is composed for clarinets, cello, electronics, sculptures and digital colour field imagery. The performers navigate through the rich electroacoustic sound fields sourced from diverse areas such as the deep waters of the Southern Ocean and the Mungo desert, to the flash storms of the bush and the wetland ranges. The sculptures are designed as timers to help reflect the balance between water and earth and the role we are playing in its care and destruction. It takes its title from Maude Barlow's book of the same name referencing water as the new industrial economy, the commodity of the 21st Century. *Blue Gold* challenges us to shift our collective thinking and actions towards water at a time when water management and governance are critical issues of contemporary society.

Prior to this research, the author was inspired by the content of this work and curated two programs featuring *Blue Gold* in the context of a concert hall. The intention of this work is to shift our collective thinking and actions towards water in a live performance, but is 33 minutes really enough time? The initial data suggested that *Blue Gold* is a rich and immersive experience, but was perceived more as provocation as oppose to generating a paradigmatic shift in thinking. The thematic intention of this work was ideal to test the validity of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework* outside of the author's creative practice. Therefore in May 2011, the work was completely recontextualised as a site-specific interpretation over a Lake in one of the most pristine natural environments in Australia.

Ros Bandt participated in a dynamic ten-day program of community workshops, sound walks, forums and interactive labs designed to confront and challenge a spectrum of water issues across disciplines. The entire process was embedded in *Floating Land* 2011; one of Australia's leading art and ecology events on Lake Coorthaba in the *UNESCO* listed Biosphere of Noosa in Queensland. Over the ten days Bandt engaged in an intense process of recontexualising *Blue Gold* for this natural environment, alongside visiting national and international artists who were responding to a similar theme. *Blue Gold* became a vehicle for these conversations, ideas and actions that rippled throughout the community, a community that was changed by this process as evident in their actions and enthusiastic preparations for *Floating Land* 2013. The beginnings of a shift are without doubt present within this community, and it was clear this was as a result of implementing the five stages of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework* underpinned by the intentions of Bandt's *Blue Gold.*

CASE STUDY: REMNANT BREATH

The second case study is *Remnant Breath*, an interactive sound walk commissioned for *EcoSapiens*, New Zealand in January 2011. *EcoSapiens* is an initiative of *SCANZ;* New Zealand's premier art, technology, culture and ecology event and involves a symposium, creative residency, and public events and exhibitions. The commission itself was for the *Remnant Emergency Artlab*, which is an Australian government funded interdisciplinary research project pivoting on site-specific cultural exchange labs across the globe. As a result of embedding the project within the context of a creative residency, many aspects of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework* were already in place. This case study was therefore used as an observation process, adapting elements of the community engagement model and exploring the process on a considerably smaller scale in comparison to *Blue Gold*.

Remnant Breath was conceived and directed by the author in collaboration with Australian media artist Keith Armstrong and Maori musician/artist Jo Tito. The intention of the work was to reveal remnant sonic layers in the Tehenui rainforest walkway leading to the ocean in New Plymouth. Through a 20-minute immersive experience the work explored stories of water, breath, place and the Maori concept of interconnection and the environment. Remnants (of land, animal life or cultures) offer a warning, because they signal both loss and disconnection and the need for urgent action. So by inviting an acute sensitisation to place solely through the often ignored sense of sound, a powerful context was created for these experiences and conversations. Placing speakers along the path leading towards a live performance from Jo Tito augmented the Tehenui's

existing dense sonic environment. The audience was blindfolded for the entire performance and guided in small groups through the work. The positive responses suggested the intentions of the work were conveyed and conversations began to expand the work.

The community engagement aspects of this project involved a series of workshops designed to accompany this project, in this particular context the workshops were directed at a younger demographic, specifically 8 -15 year olds. As the future leaders, it is this generation who will be dealing with the true ramifications of humanities actions. Through this research it has become clear that encouraging young people to listen to the environment is one the most immediate and effective remedies to facilitate this shift. These workshops included sound walks and field recording sessions in addition to participating in the final event. While there wasn't a large amount of participants, the students involved left with a different perception of interacting and experiencing the environment. The visual data also clearly displays their shift in awareness before and after the workshop, simply in the way they are treading lightly on the natural environment. This project also generated a range of significant partnerships and ongoing collaborations, but the most significant outcome was clearly the critical need to engage a younger demographic in the *Sonic Ecologies* process.

CASE STUDY: SONIC BABYLON

Sonic Babylon is the creation of New York based artists Nora Farrell and Bill Duckworth, who have spent a significant amount of time in Australia developing interactive sound gardens across the country branded as *Sonic Babylon*. Riding local Wi-Fi networks, the *Sonic Babylon* sound gardens grows with music, sounds, and stories accessible on mobile devices in selected spaces within a community. The sound garden is interactive and can be both heard and manipulated by the community. As visitors move through the garden, the *Sonic Babylon* application tracks their position in the space and the 3D audio engine generates a real-time sound mix relative to the location of the planted sounds.

Sonic Babylon is built on the Tactical Sound Garden [TSG] Toolkit, an open source software platform for cultivating public "sound gardens" within contemporary cities. This is drawing on the culture of urban community gardening and is framed around creating a participatory environment for social interaction through technology. The central idea is to ride existing Wi-Fi nodes in urban cities, but the potential outcomes could be just as relevant, if not more beneficial, in regional area if the appropriate amount of Wi-Fi nodes were installed.

As a direct result of this research, the first regional version of *Sonic Babylon* was installed at the Noosa Regional Gallery on the Noosa River and in late 2010, a partnering regional sound garden was installed at the Mill Place Precinct on the Sunshine Coast with the aid of funding stemming from the urban planning sectors of state government. The project was rebranded as *{neo}sonic*, and designed to capture and connect the voices of global communities through sound based art and technology. The multi-platform nature of the project involved a virtual orchestra, indigenous soundscapes and community engagement workshops which all fed into the sound garden.

Sound Gardens have a diversity of positive outcomes for a community including the ability to repurpose existing digital content (such as oral history) and also the ability to observe a system, a virtual ecology, and hear what kind of voices and themes may arise. The key attraction is its accessibility and versatility, and its ability to grow within a community over time. In the context of *Sonic Ecologies* it can function as both the core creative work and the ongoing community engagement. It basically functions as part of the ongoing ecology of the process as oppose to an independent creative outcome. The majority of the sound materials planted in the garden initially were historic recordings, particularly revolving around the indigenous history of the region. It was extremely rewarding to see young people interacting with Sonic Babylon and gaining insight into the indigenous history of the area, learning aspects of the local Gubbi Gubbi language and clearly feeling engaged and connected.

This case study also became an observation to prove the validity and necessity of the final stages of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework*. The *{neo}sonic* process received support from local, state and federal government in the initial stages, but unfortunately there was not ongoing support and community engagement provided. It is logical that if the community engagement is not sustained, the project will gradually dissolve. It is also worthy to note that the majority of people in a regional area, particularly of the older demographic, don't have the capacity to interact with this technology without initially being guided and mentored through the process. So while the installment of *Sonic Babylon* was engaging for the community and deemed successful, this research has identified a significant area of improvement in the development of ongoing sustainable strategies. This is not necessarily about delivering a two-week workshop program along with the install, but more about developing strategic partnerships and long-term community engagement strategies that accompany a project of this nature. Although this particular case study has also produced rewarding results, it has sparked the beginning of research into interdisciplinary partnerships to deliver projects over sustained periods.

BIOSPHERE SOUNDSCAPES

The *Biosphere Soundscapes* project, currently in its first phase of research and investigation, illustrates the

conceptual design of a major international project highlighting the future possibilities of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework. Biosphere Soundscapes* pivots on a network of site-specific creative project embedded in multi-layered community engagement processes within global Biosphere Reserves. This evolving process is implemented by sound artists, acting as agents of change spiraling between contextualised theory and practice. The content generated is embedded in a virtual network of global Biosphere Reserves via google earth technology and shared though the *BioScapes* community on the *PlaceStories* system developed by *Feral Arts*. The process and creative outcomes are delivered by a core team of artists and advisors who are ultimately acting as catalysts for a global participatory environmental project accessible to anyone with an internet connection. *Biosphere Soundscapes* is designed to inspire communities across the world to listen to the environment and re-imagine the potential of Biospheres as learning laboratories for a sustainable future. This project combines art, science, technology and community to give Biosphere Reserves across the world a voice and a global audience to listen.

Composed of 580 sites in 114 countries, Biosphere Reserves are sites recognised under *UNESCO's Man and the Biosphere (MAB)* programme to promote sustainable development based on local community efforts and sound science. As places that seek to reconcile conservation of biological and cultural diversity and social development through partnerships between people and nature, they are ideal to test and demonstrate innovative approaches to sustainable development and represent a unique tool for international collaborations through sharing knowledge, exchanging experiences and building capacity for interdisciplinary partnerships. This will be the first major international sound project for the *World Network of Biosphere Reserves.*

The methodological grounding for *Biosphere Soundscapes* revolves around the creative possibilities of Soundscape Ecology, a rapidly evolving field of biology, where scientists record a given habitat and listen for patterns and changes to form an analysis of the health of the environment. The process of working with each Biosphere will modify depending on the collaborating artists and accessibility of the local community, but in any case it will be grounded in each stage of the *Sonic Ecologies Framework*. In some cases the process will involve sound labs, artist residencies and extensive community engagement, while in other cases the key community stakeholders of the Biosphere Reserve can generate content independently and engage via the website.

The first stage of delivering this project is focused on two Australian Biospheres; the Noosa Biosphere and the Great Sandy Biosphere, both situated in Queensland. The research lab for *Biosphere Soundscapes* will launch on *World Listening Day* 2012 (July 18) with an interactive sound walk and community activities in the Noosa Biosphere. The initial support, interest and committed partnerships solidify the validity of this project and highlight the potential role electroacoustic composers could play in ecological crisis.

CONCLUSION

The *Sonic Ecologies Framework* is not a complex idea, it is simple, based on logic and grounded in significant practice-led research outcomes. As a result, it is accessible for artists interested in implementing similar projects on a local and global scale. While the author will continue facilitating projects through this process, it is also hoped the wider sound community will grasp the potential of delivering work with this methodology.

Now, more than ever before there is a critical need to listen to our environment and generate a paradigm shift that engages our auditory perception. Sound, as a creative medium, is undoubtedly one of the most powerful means to stimulate this shift in consciousness. Electroacoustic music, with the use of natural sounds exposing the state of the world could be an unprecedented tool in artists taking action in ecological crisis. This research is ultimately underpinned by the realisation that artists can play a role in creating a sustainable future, and as proposed by Joel Chadabe, think of ourselves as "leaders in a magnificent revolution" [3].

REFERENCES

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